

Depression

People often say “I’m depressed” when they are sad. But in fact, depression lasts longer than the feeling that comes when something or upsetting has happened. Depression may be triggered by experiencing a traumatic event, such as the loss of a loved one, moving to a new home, or changing schools, but sometimes it can happen for no reason at all. People who are depressed feel persistently down and usually experience one or more of the following symptoms.

Symptoms

Constantly feeling sad, low, or worthless; sometimes irritable or tearful

- Losing interest or pleasure in normally enjoyable things
- Having difficulty concentrating and making decisions
- Feeling unable to fall asleep, and sleeping less or more than usual
- Changes in appetite and subsequent weight loss or gain
- Headaches, tiredness or loss of energy, and feeling restless

ALERT!

Suicidal feelings

Suicide is the act of intentionally ending your own life. Sometimes people with depression, or those experiencing intolerable feelings, can start to feel that their life isn’t worth living. This feeling is usually temporary, but it’s essential to seek help immediately if you feel this way.

For some people, it helps to speak to someone they don’t know. There are phone helplines available 24 hours a day, every day of the year, or counselors that can be reached by text or email.

If you’re worried for a friend, encourage them to talk about their feelings and listen carefully. Advise them to get help as quickly as possible. They may seem to push you away or appear indifferent at first, but stick by them and offer your support.

See the doctor

A nurse or doctor will be able to help if further support is needed.



Medical treatment

When anxiety and depression persist, the doctor may prescribe medication.



Counseling

Talking is one of the first and best steps to get help with anxiety and depression.



Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)

CBT is a method of changing negative thought patterns.



What to avoid

There are some pitfalls to avoid if a teen is feeling anxious or depressed.

Too much time online

Be smart about online time. Too much, especially on social media, may worsen a teen’s mood.



Alcohol or drugs

Don’t rely on these for a mood boost. They make anxiety and depression worse.

